FIRST CUSTOMER

First Customer — 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers — Day 6: The First-Customer Offer: Pilots and Launch Deals

Study guide · Self-study

10 Days to Your First Paying Customers · Day 6: The First-Customer Offer: Pilots and Launch Deals

How to Use This Guide

This guide is for you, the founder with no customers yet and a real offer to test. Work through it alone, in one sitting or two. Write your answers before you look at the Model Answers at the end. The examples use fictional numbers and situations, so treat them as patterns, not as facts about your market. What matters is that you build your own version of the offer this week, with your own customers, in your own business.

- Read each section, then do the short exercises in the spaces provided.
- Write your answers in your own words. Use the Model Answers only after you have written something.
- Keep one page for your pilot or launch offer and add to it as you go.
- At the end, complete the Upskill Challenge with real prospects.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

By the end of this unit you will have a structured first-customer offer you can take to market. You will know how to reduce the buyer's risk without giving away your value. You will also practice turning interest into a paid commitment.

- Knowledge: Understand the elements of a B2B paid pilot (scope, success criteria, duration, conversion path) and a B2C founding-customer or launch offer, and why risk reversal reduces buyer fear.
- Attitude: Shift from trying to look established to embracing your status as a learning partner who delivers real value.
- Skill: Design and present a pilot or launch offer that includes risk reversal and clear success criteria.
- Upskill: Tailor the offer structure to two different customer segments and test which risk-reversal element moves the decision.

Why First Customers Need a Different Offer

You have no logos, no testimonials, no case studies. The customer knows this. Their fear is simple: if I pay you and it doesn't work, I lose money and time, and I have to explain it to my boss, my partner or myself. Your first-customer offer must lower that fear while still asking for money. Free trials often attract people who never intend to buy, and they teach you little. A paid pilot or a founding-customer deal does the opposite: it filters for serious buyers and gives you a real test. The psychology here is loss aversion: people weigh a loss more heavily than an equivalent gain. So you must make the potential loss feel small and recoverable, while the potential gain feels concrete and near.

> **NOTES**
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> Avoid the temptation to give everything away free. A paid engagement, even a small one, changes the customer's commitment and your learning.

B2B: Structuring a Paid Pilot

A paid pilot is a short, bounded project with a clear price, a start and end date, and a defined success measure. It is not a discount on your full service. It is a separate product with its own scope. Use the Discovery Sequence you learned on Day 4 to understand the customer's context, priority and constraints before you propose a pilot. Then build the pilot around their specific problem. The four elements are: Scope, Success criteria, Duration, Conversion path. Scope: exactly what you will deliver and what you will not. Success criteria: one or two measurable outcomes the customer agrees to. Duration: a fixed period, long enough to show results, short enough to limit risk. Conversion path: what happens if the pilot succeeds — a clear next step and price. For example, a SaaS founder selling to a mid-sized logistics company might propose a 30-day pilot for a fee of 3,500 (fictional) that covers onboarding, use of the tool for up to 10 users, and weekly check-ins, with success measured by a 15% reduction in order-processing time. If the pilot hits that, the customer can convert to an annual plan at a stated price. The fee is real, so the customer takes it seriously.

- Scope: list exactly what is included and excluded.
- Success criteria: one or two measurable outcomes, agreed in writing.
- Duration: fixed start and end, with a review date.
- Conversion path: what happens if success is met, including price and timing.

> **NOTES**
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> A pilot without success criteria is just a discount. Always agree the measure before you start.

B2C: Founding Customer and Launch Offers

In B2C you often sell to individuals who are risking their own money and time. A founding-customer offer works well: you give a special price or extra value in exchange for their feedback, a testimonial, and their patience as you refine the product. Be honest about the trade. For example, a founder launching a home meal-prep service might offer the first 20 customers a founding-member price of 49 per week (fictional) for the first three months, in exchange for a short feedback call each month and permission to use their comments anonymously. The price is lower than the planned regular price of 69, but it is not free. The extra value could be a free insulated bag or priority scheduling. The key is that the customer feels they are getting something real in exchange for being early, not that they are buying an unfinished product. Risk reversal here could be a money-back guarantee for the first two weeks if they are not satisfied, no questions asked.

> **NOTES**
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> Make the exchange explicit. 'Founding customer' should mean something: feedback, flexibility, or a testimonial, not just a discount.

Risk Reversal Without Giving Away the Store

Risk reversal means you take on more of the downside so the customer feels safe saying yes. Common forms: money-back guarantee, pilot fee credited toward a full purchase if they convert, a cancellation clause with notice, or a small initial payment followed by the rest on success. Each has a cost to you, so choose one that fits your economics. For a B2B pilot, you might offer that the pilot fee is fully credited toward the first year's subscription if they sign within 30 days of a successful pilot. That reduces their risk (they don't pay twice) and gives them a reason to decide quickly. For B2C, a satisfaction guarantee for a defined period works if your product can be returned or refunded without breaking your cash flow. Be specific: 'If you are not satisfied within 14 days, I will refund your payment in full.' Vague promises create suspicion. The psychology is that a concrete, limited guarantee feels more credible than an unlimited one, and it gives the buyer a clear picture of what happens if things go wrong.

> **NOTES**
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> Only promise what you can afford to deliver. A guarantee you cannot honor will damage your reputation more than no guarantee.

Building Confidence When You Have Zero Customers

You cannot claim results you don't have. But you can demonstrate your process, your knowledge, and your commitment. Emphasize that you are selecting a small number of early customers to work closely with, and that you will be personally involved. This is Klaff's Prize Frame (Pitch Anything; Klaff), used honestly: you are evaluating fit as much as they are. You can say, "I'm working with a small group of early customers to make sure the product fits their needs. I want to be sure this is a good match before we start." That signals you are not desperate. It flips the dynamic from "please buy" to "let's see if this works for both of us." The customer's fear of being a guinea pig is reduced because you are setting clear boundaries and success criteria. You are not pretending to be big; you are being a credible partner.

The psychology is mutual evaluation. People take a conversation more seriously when the other side is also deciding. A seller who has already decided to accept anyone feels low value, and buyers sense it. A seller who checks fit feels credible, and buyers lean in. Keep it honest: you are not pretending to be unavailable, withholding useful information, or making the customer prove their worth. You are simply being clear that this is a partnership with boundaries, and that you will be personally involved.

> **NOTES**
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> Never fake testimonials or logos. Customers can tell, and it destroys trust. Your honesty about being new is a strength if you pair it with a clear plan.

Apply It in Your Role

Now put this into your own business. Choose whether you are designing a B2B pilot or a B2C launch offer, or both if you serve both markets. Use the table below to draft your offer. Write one line per item.

- Offer type: _____
- Target customer (from Day 1): _____
- Problem it solves: _____
- Scope (what is included): _____
- Scope (what is excluded): _____
- Success criteria (one or two measures): _____
- Duration or period: _____
- Price: _____
- Risk reversal (what you will do if it doesn't work): _____
- What you ask in return (feedback, testimonial, case study): _____
- Conversion path (what happens if successful): _____

> **NOTES**
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> Keep it simple. A pilot with too many moving parts is hard to sell and hard to run.

What Would You Say?

Write your response to each situation before you look at the Model Answers. Say it out loud so it sounds like you.

- A potential B2B customer says, 'I'm interested, but I can't justify paying for a pilot when I don't know if it will work.' Write what you would say.
- A B2C customer asks, 'Why should I pay you when you're just starting out? I could wait until you're more established.' Write your response.
- A customer agrees to a pilot but says, 'Let's not set specific success criteria; let's just see how it goes.' How do you respond?
- Your pilot customer completes the pilot but hesitates to convert to a paid plan. Write what you would say to move them toward a decision.

Key Takeaways

Here is what to remember from this unit.

- A paid pilot or founding-customer offer is a real product with scope, success criteria, duration and a conversion path.
- Risk reversal reduces buyer fear by making the downside small and recoverable; be specific and affordable.
- You don't need customer logos to be credible; you need a clear process and a genuine partnership.
- Always exchange value: a lower price or extra service should come with feedback, a testimonial, or a commitment.
- Never fake experience. Honesty about being new, paired with a structured offer, builds trust.

Quiz

Answer the five questions below. Choose the best answer for each. Write your answers down before checking the answer key in the notes.

1. What is the main purpose of a paid pilot for a first customer?

   A. To give the product away for free to get feedback.

   B. To create a low-risk, structured way for the customer to test your solution and for you to prove value.

   C. To avoid setting success criteria so the customer can't complain.

   D. To offer a large discount on your full service.

2. Which of the following is NOT one of the four elements of a B2B pilot structure?

   A. Scope

   B. Success criteria

   C. Unlimited free support

   D. Conversion path

3. A founding-customer offer in B2C typically exchanges:

   A. A free product for a testimonial.

   B. A special price or extra value for feedback and patience.

   C. A full refund for a positive review.

   D. A lifetime discount for an upfront payment.

4. Risk reversal works because:

   A. It makes the customer feel they can try without losing much if it fails.

   B. It shows you are desperate for the sale.

   C. It removes all need for a contract.

   D. It guarantees the product will work perfectly.

5. When you have no customers, how can you build confidence?

   A. Invent a few testimonials to look established.

   B. Talk about your process, your personal involvement, and your selective approach to early customers.

   C. Offer the product for free indefinitely.

   D. Avoid mentioning that you are new.

Upskill Challenge

Before Day 7, use your pilot or launch offer with three real prospects. For each, note what you proposed, how they reacted, and what you learned. Then answer the reflection questions.

- Prospect 1: name or initials, offer summary, reaction, next step, what you would change.
- Prospect 2: name or initials, offer summary, reaction, next step, what you would change.
- Prospect 3: name or initials, offer summary, reaction, next step, what you would change.
- Reflection: Which part of the offer (scope, criteria, risk reversal, price) caused the most hesitation? ____
- Reflection: What will you adjust in your offer based on these three conversations? ____

> **NOTES**
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> Aim for a mix of prospects: some warm, some cold. The goal is to learn, not to close every one.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you. The principle matters more than exact wording.

- 1. 'I understand. That's exactly why I propose a pilot: a 30-day project with clear success measures we agree on. You pay a pilot fee, and if we hit the measures, that fee is credited toward your first year. If we don't hit them, you don't continue and you've lost only the pilot fee, which is small compared to the risk of doing nothing. What would success need to look like for you after the pilot?'
- 2. 'I'm new, and that's actually good for you. You get my full attention and I'm building my reputation on your results. I offer a founding-customer price and a satisfaction guarantee: if you're not happy in the first two weeks, I'll refund you. In return, I ask for honest feedback so I can improve. Does that sound fair?'
- 3. 'I understand the appeal of keeping it loose, but without clear criteria we won't know if it worked, and that's not fair to either of us. Let's pick one or two simple measures you care about. If we hit them, we both have a clear reason to continue. If not, we part ways with no hard feelings. What would success look like for you?'

- 4. 'You've completed the pilot and we hit the success criteria we agreed on: processing time down by 18% and your team using the tool daily. The next step is the annual plan we discussed, at the price we set. I can send the paperwork today, or if you need more time to decide, let's schedule a call for Monday. What works better for you?'
- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. A paid pilot filters for serious buyers and provides a structured test with clear criteria.
- 2. C. Unlimited free support is not a structural element; the four are scope, success criteria, duration, and conversion path.
- 3. B. Founding customers get a special price or extra value in exchange for feedback and patience.
- 4. A. Risk reversal reduces the fear of loss by making the downside small and recoverable.
- 5. B. Emphasize your process and personal involvement rather than faking social proof.

> **NOTES**
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> Notice how each model acknowledges the concern and offers a concrete step, without pressure.

References

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